



Support system: Pratika with her parents, Pradeep and Rajni, at their West Patel Nagar home in New Delhi. The family that steadied her through injury now shares the joy of India's World Cup triumph. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

compartmentalisation. It began when she was young and idealistic, trying to understand why criminals and serial killers behave the way they do, so she could prevent them from committing harm and save society. As she evolved as an athlete, that curiosity helped her more internally.

"Psychology deals with human behaviour and emotions. I wanted to get a hold of that, know how to alter emotions, because they can get you in a lot of trouble when it is not going your way. Mom always used to tell me stories from the Ramayana and Mahabharat, and I remember one where Krishna ji tells Arjun that your mind can be your best friend and worst enemy.

"I love reading about disorders. I got so obsessed with it that my mom had to intervene and say, '*Disorders hi kyun padh rahi hai? Kuch aur padh le* (Why are you only reading about disorders? Read something else)'.

"I learnt about different types of stress: eustress (good) and distress (bad). It helped me figure out management techniques, what I should and shouldn't do in heated situations, and more."

All that composure and

space-making for the self will be needed now more than ever as she navigates the difficulty of a life of stillness. "I am not worried about failure, I am about stagnation," she says.

Room to celebrate

A person whose vacations involve making to-do lists and tweaking exercise regimes has now been forced to pause and look around, and smell the flowers. Despite being in a wheelchair and needing crutches to walk, Pratika's days have been anything but relaxed, with countless media engagements, VIP visits, shoots, and felicitations coming her way. But what she remembers most is the sweep of emotions when India became world champion at the stroke of midnight and her own little part in that historic moment.

"My dad couldn't control his emotions when the team came to escort me to the ground. He was screaming. A lot of raw emotions. But I remember my mom calling me. She is someone who sleeps early. She can't stay up late, but she did that day. Dad asked her why she was still awake, and she said, 'My

daughter has won the country a World Cup. How can I sleep?' She was so happy. My brother never posts on Instagram, and he put up a story saying he was proud of me."

Her circle has also kept her humble through the ups and downs of a life in cricket. "My coach always says, look to the sky but keep your feet on the ground. She always reminds me of things I still have to do. We keep being told not to dwell on the past when things go wrong. It should apply when successes come too. After all, we have to start from scratch the next time we take to the field."

Pratika is not one for big celebrations or even tattooing the World Cup trophy on her body. For someone who walked off a cricket field with a broken ankle, she is petrified of needles.

"Maybe that's my disorder," she says cheekily. But she does maintain a diary she calls the *Record Book*.

"I keep a lot of goals and milestones written there. Winning the World Cup was one of them." A very satisfying strike awaits this dreamer as she gets started with her pursuit of greatness.